Homesick Here

Solastalgia

"...solastalgia is the distress that is produced by environmental change impacting on people while they are directly connected to their home environment."

Glenn Albrecht and colleagues

In this scoping review, we focus on the scholarly literature that uses solastalgia as a lens for examining emotional, mental, and spiritual health dimensions of climatic and environmental change. Although there is a range of related concepts used to understand environmentally-induced distress and the associated health impacts, ecological grief and eco-anxiety as key examples, we have not reviewed any such related concepts here. A key theoretical aspect of solastalgia that sets it apart from related concepts is an explicit focus on place: solastalgia is a place-based lived experience. ...

Lindsay P. Galway and colleagues

"A key theoretical aspect of solastalgia that sets it apart from related concepts is an explicit focus on place: solastalgia is a place-based lived experience."

Lindsay P. Galway and colleagues

Drawing on the construct of landscape as described above, we define solastalgia as the distress caused by the unwelcome transformation of cherished landscapes resulting in cumulative mental, emotional, and spiritual health impacts. While initial solastalgia scales used a place descriptor of a specific location, in much of the solastalgia literature, place is described using the idea of 'home'; we use 'cherished landscapes' instead. 'Cherished', to emphasize the deep emotional attachment to places that is common among those experiencing solastalgia. ...

Lindsay P. Galway and colleagues

Homesick Here

Rooms

Objects

Actions

Seasons

What remains

Home
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Here

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Context

I. Rooms

Details

"And I went to where my mother's were and there was somebody working on it, I said: "is there any chance of having a look inside it?" You know, for memories, and I shouldn't have gone in because they'd gutted it."

James, Pendleton resident

Quoted by Lomas and colleagues

Here, James describes the emotional impact of perceived harm to a property with associations with a significant other, in this case, his mother. James described holding a strong emotional bond with his mother, who had passed away approximately fifteen years prior to the current interview. What his accounts seemed to be demonstrating is how, over time, the significant emotional bond he shared with his mother became associated with the physical environment. In hearing his description of the physical degradation of structures, he appears to highlight how this is experienced as emotional pain. ...

Michael J. Lomas, Eunice Ayodeji and Philip Brown

Rooms

Details

Context

"It's just going to look odd though (pause) It's a shame really that Northern Counties aren't thinking (pause) well, they're all doing it up, why don't we do ours as well? Because it's going to look stupid, to be honest."

Rebecca, Pendleton resident

Quoted by Lomas and colleagues

Although previously seeming to hold no negative attitudes toward her property, the modernization of a neighboring block has led Rebecca to reconsider her home, with her now regarding it less favourably. As the physical features of a place change, so do individuals' perceptions and understandings of it. We can understand this in relation to the concept of place definition, the underlying process of place attachment encompassing the environmental elements that contribute to individuals' understanding of a location, providing it with a form of identity. ...

Michael J. Lomas, Eunice Ayodeji and Philip Brown





Rooms

Details

Context

Rooms



"It was white tiles. It was made of white tiles, and it was quite tall... That was at the top of this road (pause) That's where this landmark this was. And the rest of it, it was either pubs or churches. They were landmarks. Like, if you knew where Pendleton Church was, you could direct people – in a few directions from Pendleton Church to wherever."

Mae, Pendleton resident

Quoted by Lomas and colleagues

Not only do changes in physical structure change one's understanding of place but also their sense of familiarity with it. Here, Mae describes the removal of an art-deco monument once present in Pendleton, which she deemed to be a defining characteristic of the local area. Now this has been removed, the place has become less familiar, with consequences for navigation. As a result of such changes, several participants thus describe a sense of disorientation in a once familiar location.

Michael J. Lomas, Eunice Ayodeji and Philip Brown

Context

II. Objects

Details

Objects

Home was also expressed as a place for continuity. Objects and furniture in the home were carefully chosen and created a personal atmosphere. Many of the participants described feeling at home, surrounded by emotionally meaningful objects, as being closely related to well-being. This is illustrated by a 69-year-old woman, living in a flat in a small municipality, reflected on her experience of home as follows:

Maya Kylén and colleagues

"...it is familiar in a way, I see my belongings that I had for a long time..."
Participant, 69-year-old woman
Quoted by Maya Kylén and colleagues

The subcategory "Living in a well-designed place geared to individual needs" was related to the physical attributes inside the home. The home was made more usable through equipment chosen to fulfil specific needs, expressed through statements like "When we bought a new bed we chose one that´s adjustable" or "Our new TV is on wheels so it´s easy to move around". ...

Maya Kylén and colleagues





Objects



Details

Context

Objects

The focus now shifts to the myriad losses and upheavals that feature heavily across the Gippsland narratives. Separating the losses and impacts of the bushfires into neat categories is complicated. For those who were burnt out, the primary focus was on loss of home and possessions—the repercussions that flowed from what Read eloquently describes as the "journey to nothing". For these men and women, objects saved during evacuation and objects distorted by extreme heat were sometimes given new meanings. Tension or changes (positive and negative) in relationships, loss of the natural landscape, concerns about mental health and wellbeing, new friendships and community connections were discussed by those whose homes survived or remained habitable immediately after the fires and those who were burnt out. The experiences of the burnt and the unburnt intersect and yet each individual has his or her own unique post-bushfire experience.

Mae Proudley

Objects

Home was also expressed as a place for continuity. Objects and furniture in the home were carefully chosen and created a personal atmosphere. Many of the participants described feeling at home, surrounded by emotionally meaningful objects, as being closely related to well-being. This is illustrated by a 69-year-old woman, living in a flat in a small municipality, reflected on her experience of home as follows:

"It is cozy and...I feel good when I come home [...] it is familiar in a way, I see my belongings that I had for a long time and I come home to...yes it feels warm, but I can't explain why [...] it brings certainty, that's what it is."

Maya Kylén and colleagues








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III. Actions

"I go out, I think I have... the stones know me, I go out and..."

EM31, Madrid resident, age 86

Quoted by Irene Lebrusán and M. Victoria Gómez



"We have taken this walk almost every day in the months since we arrived."

Malachy Tallack

"I load my car with water and nonperishables. I check various maps and apps, mesmerized by the fires in almost every direction."

Claire Vaye Watkins

"...I can't control the weather, so I need to take steps to manage what I do with my plants and my emotions..."

Monica, Western Australia

Quoted by Petra Tschakert and colleagues

Over the 100+ hours of Walking Journeys, we had the privilege of being invited inside many Places of the Heart.

We meandered through, around, and into small veggie patches and expensively landscaped gardens, modest government housing and mansion-like residences, rural cemeteries and churches, and up and down distinctive landscape features across Noongar Boodja (the Country of the Noongar peoples) such as granite outcrops, creeks, river valleys, and pools, all of which are imbued with Indigenous history and cultural significance. ...

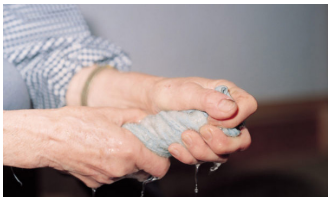
Petra Tschakert and colleagues

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"Look, I have a flat in Villalba. It is very nice. Nicer than this one because this is a fourth floor without a lift. You can get an idea, 90 steps. Well, I don't know. I go out, I think I have... the stones know me, I go out and... It's not that I'm out of my mind, no. It's that I like the neighbourhood more than anything else."

EM3l, Madrid resident, age 86

Quoted by Irene Lebrusán and M. Victoria Gómez

"... We've got national parks on three sides of our property. Their prescribed burning is inadequate; there is this increased fuel load all around us, and the risk of out-of-control fires. This restricts your lifestyle. We don't go away over the summer so we can protect the house.... I'm not happy when I hear the helicopters coming. We've had a big bushfire here earlier in the year. It's devastating when you go for walks and there are dead animals and it's still smouldering"

Carol, Perth Hills resident

Quoted by Petra Tschakert and colleagues

"We nudged each other towards noticing."

Malachy Tallack

Context

Details

Actions

Actions

Given that these were all special places and spaces in which people relax, cherish memories, seek peace and solitude, and find therapeutic escapes and solace, almost all emotional states conveyed to us about these places emphasised enjoyment, pleasure, happiness, joy, involvement, interest, pride, and/or elation. The last was particularly the case for domestic spaces such as houses, gardens, and farms over which participants expressed most control; they enable active emotional and material beautification and creation that further intensify place attachment.

...

Monica, a single mother in a so-called rural SuperTown 100 km inland, is rather angry about the more frequent hot days and frost that afflict her small garden paradise, but she tries to keep her emotions at bay:

Petra Tschakert and colleagues

"If you let bad emotions get a hold of you, you spiral. I can't control the weather, so I need to take steps to manage what I do with my plants and my emotions ... like building a living shade"

Monica, Western Australia

Quoted by Tschakert and colleagues

Actions

Details

Context



Others were similarly inclined to blame environmental problems on political incompetence and failure in governance; for example, in a tree-changer community in the Perth Hills, several residents were exasperated about what they see as irresponsible bushfire risk management. For instance, Carol, when considering the reality of hotter and longer summers and the increased frequency and severity of bushfires, gave a maximum score of irritation and anger on the Wheel:

Petra Tschakert and colleagues

"The government ignores the fire risk .... We've got national parks on three sides of our property. Their prescribed burning is inadequate; there is this increased fuel load all around us, and the risk of out-of-control fires. This restricts your lifestyle. We don't go away over the summer so we can protect the house.... I'm not happy when I hear the helicopters coming. We've had a big bushfire here earlier in the year. It's devastating when you go for walks and there are dead animals and it's still smouldering"

Carol, Perth Hills resident

Quoted by Tschakert and colleagues

IV. Seasons





Seasons

"Snow conditions have changed so much."

Reindeer-herder respondent, Finnish Sámi Homeland

Quoted by Inkeri Markkula and colleagues





IV. Seasons

"...and then you wake up to four inches of snow that doesn't go away but before the ground or ice freezes"

Neil Kigutaq

Quoted by Ossie Michelin



"In response, many reported that they had lost confidence in the consistency of the seasons and in their ability to predict future weather."

Neville R. Ellis and

Glenn A. Albrecht

Moreover, unpredictability in weather causes both acute and long-term stress. When it is not possible to predict the weather conditions, herders feel that they need to be "prepared for everything". At the same time, there is a growing concern over the future of reindeer herding as a livelihood.

When interviews took place, the participants had just experienced two winters which were very difficult for reindeer herding: many participants described the winter 2019–2020 as the snowiest they had ever seen and the winter 2021–2022 as the most difficult in their whole lifetime.

Inkeri Markkula and colleagues

"Winds carrying dry leaves were a caution. Chimney smoke was not a sign of warmth in autumn, but a trigger."

Erica Tom

"Like even around Halloween time we would have snow."

Young woman, Rigolet

Quoted by Joanna Petrasek MacDonald and colleagues

These extreme winter weather events, together with more gradual changes in winter weather, evoked grief over loss of traditional knowledge and grief associated with anticipated future losses among the participants. Winters 2019–20 and 2021–22 were seen as harbinger of future by the participants and evoked fear over the future of reindeer herding as a source of livelihood. Most of them had been wondering whether reindeer herding still exists 20 years from now.

Some of the participants expressed concerns that consideration of combined impacts of climate change, land use and economic issues may make reindeer herding as a livelihood appear as an impossible or undesirable way of life for younger generations.

Inkeri Markkula and colleagues

Context

Details

Seasons

Seasons

Impacts of climate change are experienced in the study area particularly in winter. The length and characteristics of seasons, the duration of snow cover, and the amount and structure of snow have all changed over the last decades, the average temperature has risen by 2.3 °C since the post-industrial period, and the snow-free season is becoming longer.

In recent years, reindeer herders in the study area have needed to cope with extremely difficult snow conditions.

Inkeri Markkula and colleagues

"Snow conditions have changed so much. You no longer know what you get and when."

"It is no longer possible to predict ice conditions. It impacts movement of people, where you can go and which way to take."

Reindeer-herder participant quotations
Quoted by Markkula and colleagues

"I am very concerned, afraid of what's going to happen. Is it possible to continue [herding] this way. Maybe I still can but what about the next generations. Will there be prerequisites for it [herding]? Will reindeer be able to live here, or anything or anyone."

Anonymous reindeer herder

Quoted by Markkula and colleagues

Participants described their connection with reindeer, the happiness they feel when in the woods and when autumn round-ups start, and their joy of seeing the new-born calves in spring.

Some of them also expressed worry over how reindeer and other animals will survive in a warmer world.

Inkeri Markkula and colleagues





Context

V. What Remains

Details



The consultation with the local community cannot commence in a meaningful way until fire-affected people are allowed time to process the event—their input is crucial. Within the Gippsland narratives, across the burnt and the unburnt, men and women emphasised how time consuming it can be to re-establish their homes, gardens, routines and lives. Often, when they have reached the point of being able to engage with or contribute to the recovery effort at a community level it is too late.

What comes through clearly in the Gippsland narratives is that the reconstruction of home and everyday routines is not a linear process. Several men and women who lost everything in the fires stressed that, for them, it only got harder with time.

Mae Proudley

"Yeah, that's what – I think probably of everything that's the thing that I would like to get any sort of message out to anyone whose managing this stuff in the future or even now, that it's actually harder now to get yourself sorted, keep things going, than it ever was."

Anonymous male participant, 40s

Quoted by Mae Proudley

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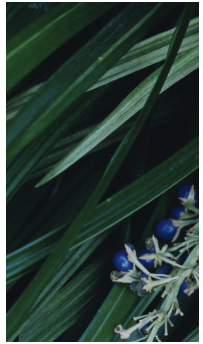


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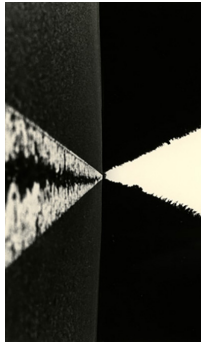
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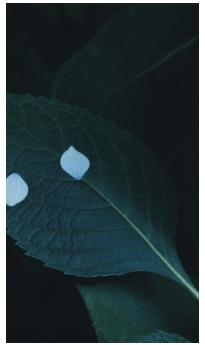
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Context

Details

What remains

One word that is peppered across the Gippsland narratives is 'control.' For those who lost their home and possessions the decision that was required, to rebuild or relocate, was sudden and unwelcome. This major life decision was triggered by a bushfire— one that was the result of arson.

[...]

One man, who was burnt out and quickly rebuilt, spoke about ongoing unsettledness. His family was relieved to escape the cramped conditions of their temporary accommodation and appreciated the space offered by their new home,

Mae Proudley

"But it's sterile, it's still sterile now. The worst thing about – I don't know, everyday it's a different worse thing, but one of the most difficult things about losing everything in a fire, and I guess people lose to house fires all the time, but it totally changed everything about our place, not just the inside, not just the house, not just our stuff, but all our history. Basically it just wiped us, for the last 14 years, off the planet."

Anonymous male participant, 40s

Quoted by Mae Proudley

Another family that rebuilt (she wanted to, he didn't) had their house up for sale at the time of the interview. In a similar vein, when they first moved into the new house ("44 weeks to the day we were stuck in Traralgon") they were simply grateful to be back on their five acres.

"But to this day it still doesn't feel like home, it's just a house, and I think a lot of it is because we resent it, because we had to do it.....if we had a bit more hindsight, or thought it through a bit more we wouldn't have rebuilt."

Mae Proudley

Anonymous female participant, 40s





... You can no longer do the things you do, of course. But I've run the house. Everything, everything, everything, all the chores, and I've been doing everything, everything, everything. All the meals... well, an assistant comes once a week and she cleans everything for me, but the rest of everything, the ironing... Everything (...) I've taken care of. Well, that's probably why I didn't consider myself... I was still valid.

EM5, Madrid resident, age 85

Quoted by Irene Lebrusán and M. Victoria Gómez

“It became an intimacy.”

Malachy Tallack

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TYPE
Instrument Serif Regular and Italic

FORMAT
64 interior pages · 160 × 250 mm · 3 mm bleed
Eight signatures of eight pages
Exposed-spine hardcover